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Suriname Death Certificates (1845-1915) Data Description

Content:

1. Introduction 1
2. Files 2
3. Data quality 2
4. Variable overview 4

Appendix:

A. Extensive variable description 6
B. Work in progress 11

1. Introduction

In 1828 in the Dutch colony of Suriname a civil registry was introduced according to the Dutch civil registration model (which in turn was based on the model introduced during the First French Republic). Suriname is a former Dutch plantation colony on the northern coast of South America, which became an independent country in 1975. During colonial times, it consisted of one city, Paramaribo, and a varying number of rural districts.

Unlike in the Netherlands, the civil registry did not immediately apply to the entire population. Two groups of people were not registered. First, people in slavery were excluded, they were noted down in the separate slave registers. Only after they were freed from slavery did the enter into the civil registry, which was for the fast majority of enslaved people after the abolition of slavery on July 1, 1863. Second, people living outside of the colonial context were not registered either. This included most of the inhabitants of the interior who were missing from the civil registry until after the Second World War. Accordingly, maroons and indigenous people were only registered if they had a child or died in Paramaribo or the colonial districts, or if they married someone who was already registered.

Free residents of Suriname were legally obliged to report every birth, death, marriage, acknowledgement, and divorce to a registrar. In this database you will find the death certificates issued in Suriname´s capital city Paramaribo (1858-1915) and the certificates issued in the Surinamese districts (1845-1852 and 1864-1880) as recorded by the registrar. The death certificates contain information on the death, the deceased person, the parents of the deceased, the (former) spouses of the deceased, the informant, and the two witnesses.

For the interested public, the information from this release has already been made available on the website of the National Archive of Suriname (NAS) in a searchable format, where also the scans of the original certificates may be found. The present release contains additional information in a structured data-base format on for example ages, places, occupations, and (il)literacy.

2. Files

The database consists of Suriname_Death_Certificates_V1.0 stored as a .csv according to the open standards.

- Commas (,) as separators
- Quotation marks (“ ”) to signal text fields
- Stored in UTF-8

Suriname_Death_Certificates_V1.0 contains information derived from 75,542 Surinamese death certificates for the period 1845-1915. Each row in the data represents a unique death certificate.

The second file contains this data description, stored as a pdf.

3. Data quality

The current release builds on a large citizen science project organized and overseen by the Historical Database Suriname and the Caribbean (HDSC) project. Hundreds of citizen scientists transcribed the Paramaribo death certificates in a collaborative effort on the Dutch citizen science platform Het Volk. To ensure high quality transcription, each certificate had been transcribed by two citizen scientists independently and checked by a third more senior citizen scientist and corrected if necessary.

The readability of the certificates and the quality of the scans is generally high and allows for straightforward transcription. However, in some cases certificates were damaged by for instance ink corrosion, and the citizen scientists were asked to add the symbol “@” for variables and letters that could not be read. The symbol “#”, in contrast, is used for variables that were not available on the certificates. To get as much information from the damaged certificates as possible, we initiated a so-called puzzle project for senior citizen scientists in which quite some time and effort was invested.

To err is human, and even though each certificate has been transcribed and controlled by three citizen scientists, transcription errors may occur occasionally. Those errors are most likely to occur for names because those are most difficult to read and to transcribe. In the future, we aim to correct for transcription mistakes.

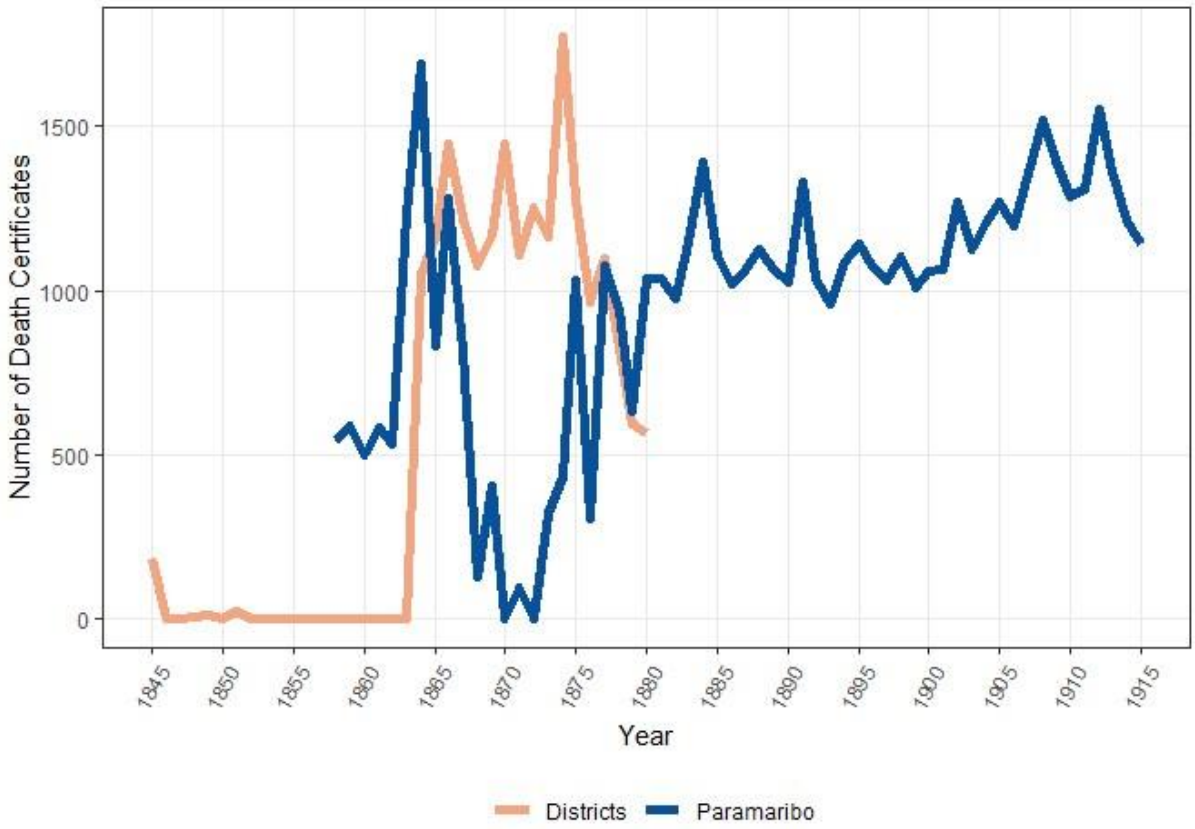
Nevertheless, the quality of the transcription is deemed to be very high. For the year 1835, 243 birth certificates were by accident entered into the transcription loop twice which enables us to judge transcription quality of the certificates in general. The child´s sex differed only in 2 cases (<1%), and the informant´s age only in 5 cases (2%) between the transcriptions of the identical certificates. The child´s first name differed in 41 cases and the informant´s last name in 42 cases (17% each), but most differing names only differed by one or two letters (for instance Isaak/Isaac and Wannen/Wanner).

A final remark concerns the completeness of this death certificates release and the availability of certificates over time. As can be seen in Figure 1, which shows the number of death certificates per year, Paramaribo death certificates are currently available for the period 1858-1915. Preceding and subsequent years will be added as soon as possible. Currently, for the period 1867-1879 certificates are not yet complete. This concerns the years 1867 (November-December), 1868 (February-December), 1869 (June-December), 1871 (February-December), 1873 (January-September), 1874 (May-

December), 1875 (September-December), 1876 (January-September), and 1879 (September). For the years 1870 and 1872 no death certificates are available at the moment. We aim to add currently missing certificates as soon as possible.

District death certificates are currently available for the years 1845-1852 and 1864-1880. Except for the so-called *boeroes*, Dutch migrant settlers who moved to Suriname in 1845 and lived for some time in their own settlement in the Saramacca district, deaths taken place before 1864 were exclusively registered in Paramaribo. This was only workable as long as almost all inhabitants of the districts were enslaved. Once slavery was abolished, the number of registrations in Paramaribo rose sharply and soon after all districts got their own registrars. District certificates issued after 1880 will be added to the current database as soon as possible.

Figure 1: The number of death certificates per year, 1845-1915



4. Variable overview

Table A1. Variable overview of the variables in Suriname_Death_Certificates_V1.0

Category	Variable	Description	Type
Certificate	id	Unique certificate identifier	constructed
	original_scanid	Scan identifier	constructed
	release	Whether it is part of Paramaribo or Districts release	constructed
	inventory_number	Inventory number from National Archives of Suriname	constructed
	projectid	Project entry identifier	constructed
	folio	Folio number of the death certificate	controlled
	cert_date	Date the certificate was issued	controlled
	cert_place	Place the certificate was issued	standardized
	cert_excerpt	Whether the death was declared in person	unaltered
Informant	inf_fname	The first name of the informant	unaltered
	inf_prefix	The surname prefix of the informant	standardized
	inf_sname	The last name of the informant	unaltered
	inf_age	Age of the informant	standardized
	inf_occ	Occupation of the informant	unaltered
	inf_place	Address of the informant	unaltered
	inf_relation	The informant's relation with the deceased	standardized
	inf_otherinfo	Other information concerning the informant	unaltered
	inf_sig	Whether informant was able to sign the certificate	constructed
	inf_sig_other	Other information about the informants' signature	unaltered
Death	death_date	Date of death	controlled
	death_daypart	Part of the day the deceased died	standardized
	death_hour	Hour of the day the deceased died	standardized
	death_place	Place where the deceased died	unaltered
	death_otherinfo	Other information about the death	unaltered
Deceased	dec_fname	First name of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_prefix	Surname prefix of the deceased person	standardized
	dec_sname	Last name of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_civilstatus	Civil status of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_age	Age of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_occ	Occupation of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_birthplace	Place where the deceased person was born	unaltered
	dec_place	Address of the deceased	unaltered
	dec_sex	Sex of the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_otherinfo	Other information about the deceased person	unaltered
	dec_prev_residence	Previous residence of the deceased person	unaltered
Parent 1	parent_fname_1	The first name of the first parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_prefix_1	The surname prefix of the first parent of the deceased	standardized
	parent_sname_1	The last name of the first parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_sex_1	The sex of the first parent of the deceased	standardized
	parent_occ_1	The occupation of the first parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_place_1	The address of the first parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_alive_1	Whether the first parent was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	parent_otherinfo_1	Other information about the first parent	unaltered
Parent 2	parent_fname_2	The first name of the second parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_prefix_2	The surname prefix of the second parent of the deceased	standardized
	parent_sname_2	The last name of the second parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_sex_2	The sex of the second parent of the deceased	standardized
	parent_occ_2	The occupation of the second parent of the deceased	unaltered
	parent_place_2	The address of the second parent of the deceased	unaltered

	parent_alive_2	Whether the second parent was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	parent_otherinfo_2	Other information about the second parent	unaltered
Spouse(s)	spouse_fname_1	The first name of the first spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_prefix_1	The surname prefix of the first spouse (if applicable)	standardized
	spouse_sname_1	The last name of the first spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_alive_1	Whether the first spouse was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	spouse_otherinfo_1	Other information about the first spouse	unaltered
	spouse_fname_2	The first name of the second spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_prefix_2	The surname prefix of the second spouse (if applicable)	standardized
	spouse_sname_2	The last name of the second spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_alive_2	Whether the second spouse was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	spouse_otherinfo_2	Other information about the second spouse	unaltered
	spouse_fname_3	The first name of the third spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_prefix_3	The surname prefix of the third spouse (if applicable)	standardized
	spouse_sname_3	The last name of the third spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_alive_3	Whether the third spouse was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	spouse_otherinfo_3	Other information about the fourth spouse	unaltered
	spouse_fname_4	The first name of the fourth spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_prefix_4	The surname prefix of the fourth spouse (if applicable)	standardized
	spouse_sname_4	The last name of the fourth spouse (if applicable)	unaltered
	spouse_alive_4	Whether the fourth spouse was alive at moment of death	unaltered
	spouse_otherinfo_4	Other information about the fourth spouse	unaltered
Witness 1	witn_fname_1	The first name of the first witness	unaltered
	witn_prefix_1	The surname prefix of the first witness	standardized
	witn_sname_1	The last name of the first witness	unaltered
	witn_age_1	Age of the first witness	standardized
	witn_occ_1	Occupation of the first witness	unaltered
	witn_place_1	Address of the first witness	unaltered
	witn_sig_1	Whether first witness was able to sign the certificate	constructed
	witn_sig_other_1	Other information about the first witness´ signature	unaltered
Witness 2	witn_fname_2	The first name of the second witness	unaltered
	witn_prefix_2	The surname prefix of the second witness	standardized
	witn_sname_2	The last name of the second witness	unaltered
	witn_age_2	Age of the second witness	standardized
	witn_occ_2	Occupation of the second witness	unaltered
	witn_place_2	Address of the second witness	unaltered
	witn_sig_2	Whether second witness was able to sign certificate	constructed
	witn_sig_other_2	Other information about second witness´ signature	unaltered
	notes_all	All notifications added by the clerk on the side of the certificate	unaltered

A. Extensive variable description

id
Unique certificate identifier which is made up of the archive number (2.10.61), the inventory number, the scan number, and whether the certificate is located on the right or left side of the scan.

original_scanid
Unique scan identifier. Each scan typically contains two death certificates. The scan identifier can be used to easily find certificates which are available online open access with the National Archives of Suriname.

inventory_number
The inventory number assigned by the National Archives of Suriname.

projectid
Paramaribo death certificates were transcribed in several badges which have their own project entry identifier. District certificates do not have their own project entry identifier.

folio
Folio number as stated on the death certificate. Folio numbers were corrected if necessary for which we used an algorithm.

cert_date
Date the certificate was issued as stated on the death certificate. Illogical dates were cross-checked with the death date and corrected manually.

cert_place
Place where the certificate was issued as stated on the death certificate. Certificate places were standardized. More than 72% of the certificates were issued in the capital city Paramaribo.

cert_excerpt
Information on whether the death was declared in person, in a letter to the registrar’s office, or extracted from the civil record of another district of community if a person had died outside his or her city or district of residence.

inf_fname
Informant´s first name as stated on the death certificate.

inf_prefix
Informant´s surname prefix as stated on the death certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

inf_sname
Informant´s last name as stated on the death certificate.

inf_age
Informant´s age as stated on the death certificate. Impossible ages (for instance 333) were corrected manually.

inf_occ
Informant´s occupation as stated on the death certificate [in Dutch].

inf_place
Informant´s address as stated on the death certificate.

inf_relation
Informant´s relation with the deceased as stated on the death certificate. The relations where standardized and corrected for typos [in Dutch].

inf_otherinfo
Additional information concerning the informant and the death as stated on the death certificate [in Dutch]

inf_sig
Constructed variable based on whether the informant was able to sign the death certificate, unable to sign due to illiteracy, unable to sign for unknown reason, did not sign because death was extracted from civil record, did not sign because the death was reported in written form, or for other reasons.

inf_sig_other
Additional information on the informant´s (in)ability to sign the death certificate [in Dutch]

death_date
Date of death as stated on the death certificate. Illogical dates were cross-checked with the certificate date and corrected manually.

death_daypart
Information on whether the deceased died before or at noon, or after noon until midnight as stated on the death certificate.

death_hour
Hour of death as stated on the death certificate. Hour of death is standardized and only contains numerical characters.

death_place
The place where the deceased died as stated on the death certificate.

death_otherinfo
Additional information concerning the death as stated on the death certificate, for example that the person drowned [in Dutch]

dec_fname
The deceased person’s first name as stated on the death certificate.

dec_prefix
The deceased person’s surname prefix as stated on the death certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

dec_sname
The deceased person’s last name as stated on the death certificate.

dec_civilstatus
The deceased person's civil status as stated on the death certificate. Categories are married, unmarried, divorced, widowed, unknown, unreadable, and not available.

dec_age
The deceased person's age as stated on the death certificate.

dec_occ
The deceased person's occupation as stated on the death certificate [in Dutch]

dec_birthplace
The deceased person's place of birth as stated on the death certificate.

dec_place
The deceased person's address as stated on the death certificate.

dec_sex
The deceased person's sex as stated on the death certificate. Categories are male, female, unreadable, unknown, and not available.

dec_otherinfo
Additional information concerning the deceased person, for example when the person was born [in Dutch].

dec_prev_residence
Where the deceased person lived previously, before moving to Suriname, as stated on the death certificate. Most mentioned places lie in the Netherlands.

parent_fname_1 & parent_fname_2
First name of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate. When the father was known, he was usually mentioned first, but this was not always the case.

parent_prefix_1 & parent_prefix_2
Surname prefix of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

parent_sname_1 & parent_sname_2
Last name of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate.

parent_sex_1 & parent_sex_2
Sex of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate. Categories are female, male, unknown, and not applicable when no parent mentioned. This variable can be used to identify the deceased person's mother or father. Mothers are mentioned much more often than fathers in the certificates.

parent_occ_1 & parent_occ_2
Occupation of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate [in Dutch].

parent_place_1 & parent_place_2
Address of the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate.

parent_alive_1 & parent_alive_2
Information on whether the first (second) parent was alive or had already died when the deceased person died.

parent_otherinfo_1 & parent_otherinfo_2
Additional information on the first (second) parent as stated on the death certificate. For instance, where and for whom the person worked before abolition of slavery [in Dutch].

spouse_fname_1, spouse_fname_2, spouse_fname_3 & spouse_fname_4
First name of the first (second, third, fourth) spouse as stated on the death certificate. Having several spouses was only possible when a previous spouse died or when a divorce had taken place. The spouses are not necessarily ordered chronologically. Most deceased persons in the dataset did not have a spouse recorded. There is only one person who had four spouses recorded.

spouse_prefix_1, spouse_preifx_2, spouse_prefix_3 & spouse_prefix_4
Surname prefix of the first (second, third, fourth) spouse as stated on the death certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

spouse_sname_1, spouse_sname_2, spouse_sname_3 & spouse_sname_4
First name of the first (second, third, fourth) spouse as stated on the death certificate.

spouse_alive_1, spouse_alive_2, spouse_alive_3 & spouse_alive_4
Information on whether the first (second, third, fourth) spouse was alive or had already died when the deceased person died.

spouse_otherinfo_1, spouse_otherinfo_2, spouse_otherinof_3 & spouse_otherinfo_4
Additional information on the first (second, third, fourth) spouse as stated on the death certificate. Very few additional information is available for the spouses [in Dutch]

witn_fname_1 & witn_fname_2
First name of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate.

witn_prefix_1 & witn_prefix_2
Surname prefix of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

witn_sname_1 & witn_sname_2
Last name of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate.

witn_age_1 & witn_age_2
Age of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate. Impossible ages (for instance 333) were corrected manually.

witn_occ_1 & witn_occ_2
Occupation of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate [in Dutch].

witn_place_1 & witn_place_2
Address of the first (second) witness as stated on the death certificate.

witn_sig_1 & witn_sig_2

Constructed variable based on whether the first (second) witness was able to sign the death certificate, unable to sign due to illiteracy, unable to sign for unknown reason, did not sign because death was extracted from civil record, did not sign because the death was reported in written form, co-signed written declaration, or for other reasons.

witn_sig_other_1 & witn_sig_other_2

Additional information on the first (second) witness' (in)ability to sign the death certificate [in Dutch].

notes_all

All notifications (*kantmeldingen*) added by the clerk on the side of the death certificate concerning text corrections (*tekstcorrectie*) and other information (*anders*). There are only very few notifications especially when compared to the birth certificates. Each notification is preceded by its category [in Dutch].

B. Work in progress

The current version of the database is work in progress. We are aware that much cleaning still has to be done. In the future, we are planning to improve the current version of the database in the following ways:

- Cleaning and standardizing all the variables referring to occupations and places.

- Cleaning and correcting all the variables referring to first names, prefixes, and last names. This allows us to identify individuals that appear several times in the database and under different roles.

- Add further death certificates both from Paramaribo (for the period before 1858 and after 1915) and the districts (for the period after 1880). Add missing certificates from the incomplete years (1867-1879) if available.

- Ultimately, we aim to link individuals not only within this death certificates release, but also with the so-called emancipation registers (which are already linked to the slave registers), and the birth certificates releases. This will allow to follow individuals and their descendants from slavery (which was abolished in 1863) up until the beginning of the 20th century.